

you full control over your account (on a shared server) or your server. There should preferably be a Web-based administration interface that will enable you to directly make configuration changes to your site without needing to call technical support. You will need to invest time and effort in choosing a host that will be able to fulfil if not exceed your needs.

Once you've determined the technical requirements of your Web site, run a search for hosting companies with your core requirements. For example, if your site depends a lot on Flash animation, your search term could be "flash support web hosting." Narrow the selection down to four or five providers that fit within your need and price band.

The next step is to search for any adverse news/comments on these Web hosts. Many Webmasters maintain blogs detailing their hosting experiences. Reviewing their feedback will help you in avoiding sleazy and second-rate hosts. A good tool to search blogs is <http://blogsearch.google.com>. Just include the hosting provider's name in your search terms to get links to the rants and raves of your potential Web host!

One fact that you need to verify is the strength of the provider's technical support. Most good hosting providers will have support personnel available 24x7 both via chat and e-mail. They should specify SLAs (Service Level Agreements) on their response times and should have sufficient skills to troubleshoot any problem you might have with the server or your account. Don't expect them to troubleshoot your Web site, though. If your chosen host does not provide detailed information about their technical support on their Web site, you'll need to write them asking them for details such as those about response times. Evasive answers, too glib replies like "don't worry, we'll handle it" are warning flags.

Also, it is a good idea to maintain complete and up-to-date offline backups of all the data and content on your Web site. This